At the same time, I said, we were possibly the only two men in the world who might be able to bring peace to the world.

I said I thought we owed it to the world to use the opportunity that had been presented us to work at building the kind of human trust and confidence in each other that could lead to genuine peace.

I watched as Gorbachev listened to the translation of my words, and he seemed to nod in agreement.

As our conversation continued beside the blazing fire, he convinced me I had been right to suspect there was a deep-seated fear of the United States and its nuclear arsenal among Soviet leaders. I tried to dispel this vision. After World War II, I pointed out, we had a monopoly on nuclear weapons, but had not used them for aggression or to exert our influence because America was not an expansionist country. We had no designs on any people or any nation; we had built our force of nuclear missiles only to deter a Soviet attack. Then we began debating the Strategic Defense Initiative; he was adamant and so was I.

I told him it was a research project to develop a nonnuclear defense that was permitted under our ABM treaty, and that if it led to an operational defensive system against missiles, it would change the world.

I said it would be years before we knew whether it was practical or not, but *if* it was, the United States would sit down with other countries to discuss how it would be used, open its laboratories to the Soviets, and offer the fruits of its research to all countries, so the entire world could enjoy security against a nuclear holocaust.

The choice we faced, I said as I wound up, was either an agreement to reduce arms or a continuation of the arms race, “and I have to tell you if it’s an arms race, you must know it’s an arms race you can’t win, because we’re not going to allow you to maintain this superiority over us.”